GLASSHOUSE

IT'S ALL GONE SOUTH

Doesn't seem like a salubrious winter for the Congress. Congress president **Mallikarjun Kharge** has run into rough weather after a breezy first year. First came the massive defeats in the three heartland states, then INDIA allies cancelled on him after he'd sent out an invite for a meeting. Now the losing veterans, including Kamal Nath and outgoing CMs Ashok Gehlot and Bhupesh Baghel, are apparently unwilling to make way for a generational shift in their states, much to the chagrin of Rahul Gandhi. Meanwhile, the Congress president is seeking to reshuffle the AICC general secretaries in the states in the run-up to the Lok Sabha polls. Amid these balancing acts came another embarrassment—the seizure of over Rs 350 crore in cash from Congress Rajya Sabha MP Dhiraj Prasad Sahu in Odisha. The cruellest cut? Ex-president Pranab Mukherjee's daughter Sharmistha's book, which reveals the late Congress leader's dim views on Rahul: "He has the arrogance of his lineage minus their political acumen."



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE





TIT FOR TAT

Political diatribes seem to have hit a new nadir in Punjab. Akali Dal leader **Bikram Majithia** recently came out with a video of CM **Bhagwant Mann's** daughter Sirat in which she alleges that he abused her mother "physically and emotionally". This was in response to Mann's personal attacks on Majithia's family members—from referring to his sister and ex-Union minister Harsimrat Kaur Badal as "Nanni Cha" (name of her NGO) to calling his great grandfather Sir Sundar Singh Majithia a "British tout". His wife Ganieve Kaur was also summoned in a drugs-related case. Earlier, Congressman and leader of the Opposition, Pratap Singh Bajwa, had started addressing the CM by his first name, showing the bitterness running through the House. Mann seems to be getting a taste of his own medicine.

HARD TASKMASTER



Senior railway officers recently got a taste of Union railway minister **Ashwini Vaishnaw's** wrath at a meeting to review safety protocols. During the video conference, Vaishnaw had a query for the Research Designs and Standards Organisation representative. The officer concerned, unfortunately, was not fully prepared and hedged a response. A miffed Vaishnaw not only ticked him off but also instructed the Railway Board CEO to take action. Last heard, he was sent on "forced leave".

A GATHERING STORM

Retired bureaucrats in Andhra Pradesh have joined up to condemn the "intolerant" political air in the state. They allege the ruling YSRCP is misusing Sec. 30 of the Police Act to stifle dissent, slap criminal cases on activists of rival parties and public organisations. The consolidation of protesters under the banner of Citizens for Democracy should be a wake-up call for CM **Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy**—assembly polls, coinciding with the Lok Sabha polls, are just months away.



DOCS ON WEDDING DUTY

Her nephews, it seems, do not share West Bengal CM **Mamata Banerjee**'s frugal tastes. The lavish wedding of her nephew Abesh, in picturesque Kurseong in Darjeeling, has sparked a furore, mostly because a hundred-strong medical team, including specialist doctors and nurses, were 'deputed' to serve the guests arriving for the celebrations (December 4-10). A circular, signed by the superintendent of the Kurseong sub-divisional hospital, which has gone viral on social media, bared the details. Incidentally, both Abesh and the bride are doctors, and the latter is a local lass. Leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikari was quick to call it a "royal family wedding" with doctors made to serve the VIPs to the neglect of the common people. Didi herself did not attend the nuptials but her other nephew and Trinamool Congress No. 2 Abhishek Banerjee did.



Kaushik Deka with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Avishek G. Dastidar, Anilesh S. Mahajan and Amarnath K. Menon